

Stage Design in SRA/TTS, Brutality, and IPSC

Executive summary

The rulebooks largely support the practical observation that IPSC stages tend to be built as defined shooting spaces using walls, ports, fault lines, and other structures, while Brutality stages can be physically simpler and rely more heavily on the written stage description and natural terrain. There are, however, two important qualifications:

- 1. **SRA is much closer to IPSC than to Brutality in its written stage-design rules.** SRA expressly provides for barricades, tunnels, boundary lines, cover lines, physical restrictions, freestyle solutions, stage briefings, and walkthrough time.
- 2. **An IPSC walkthrough enables rehearsal on how to move.** It gives every squad an orderly and substantially equal opportunity to inspect the stage. The stage remains a freestyle shooting problem, normally solved differently by different competitors.

The supplied Brutality rules require a written description, oral briefing, questions, a start condition, par time, and target requirements. They contain almost no general rules for stage construction, fault lines, walls, walkthroughs, target visibility, or equal inspection. This permits simple stages but does not require them.

Feature	IPSC Handgun	IPSC Rifle	SRA/TTS	Brutality
Detailed construction rules	Extensive	Extensive	Moderate	Minimal
Fault/boundary lines	Detailed dimensions and effects	Same core rules	Expressly regulated	Not addressed generally
Walls, barriers, ports	Detailed	Detailed, with fewer obstacle types	Barricades and tunnels allowed	Not addressed generally
Freestyle solution	Express principle	Express principle	Express principle	Not expressly stated
Written stage briefing	Detailed mandatory contents	Same, plus rifle distances	Detailed mandatory contents	Required, with limited specified contents
Walkthrough/inspection	Expressly provided	Expressly provided	Walkthrough time must be stated	Neither guaranteed nor prohibited
Equal information	Strongly protected	Strongly protected	Strongly implied and procedurally supported	Less standardized

Feature	IPSC Handgun	IPSC Rifle	SRA/TTS	Brutality
Mid-match consistency	Detailed correction/reshoot/deletion rules	Same	Reshoot or delete after material change	Allows reshoot or roughly equivalent improvisation
RO coaching	Safety warnings only	Safety warnings only	Preventive safety warning	Coaching is the default

Sources and terminology

This report compares:

- Swedish SRA/TTS rulebook, version 8.0;
- Brutality Match Rules, updated 2026-01-03;
- IPSC Handgun Competition Rules, January 2026;
- IPSC Rifle Competition Rules, January 2026.

Rule references are to those supplied documents. The SRA text is the Swedish adoption and contains Swedish additions.

Two terms must be distinguished:

- **Cold range:** firearms remain unloaded except under RO supervision. This is a firearm-handling rule.
- **Cold or blind stage:** an informal expression usually meaning that competitors have limited or no prior inspection of the stage. This is a stage-information rule.

The supplied Brutality rulebook expressly requires a **cold range** in rule 1.2. It contains no rule using “cold stage” or “blind stage,” and no express prohibition on walkthroughs. Any no-walkthrough practice must therefore come from a stage description, a separate division or event document, or local practice rather than this general rulebook.

1. Design philosophy

IPSC: a constructed freestyle shooting problem

Both IPSC books begin with the same core design principles: safety, quality, balance, diversity, freestyle, difficulty, and power (IPSC 1.1). Accuracy, power, and speed are intended to receive equal weight.

“Freestyle” is central. After the start signal, a normal course must not dictate reloads, position, location, or stance. Instead, designers may use barriers and physical restrictions to make particular positions useful or necessary (1.1.5). The distinction is important:

- the **briefing defines the problem**;
- the **physical stage limits possible solutions**;
- the **competitor chooses a solution**.

IPSC also regulates the composition of a match. Handgun has short, medium, and long courses with maximum round counts of 12, 24, and 32. Rifle uses firearm-division-dependent short-course limits, with 10 rounds for most medium courses and 20 for most long courses, subject to increases where two hits per paper target are required (1.2.1). Both recommend a 3:2:1 ratio of short, medium, and long courses.

Rifle adds a recommended distance balance: 40% of targets below 60 m, 40% from 60-150 m, and 20% from 150-300 m (Rifle 1.2.1.6). This makes IPSC Rifle more distance-driven than IPSC Handgun, while retaining the same general stage architecture.

SRA: a realistic freestyle shooting problem

SRA also expressly calls itself freestyle. Officials may not simply dictate shooting position or place, but stage construction may physically force positions or limit choices. Competitors must retain freedom over when and how a visible target is engaged (SRA 1.3.6).

This is very close to IPSC 1.1.5. The different emphasis is visible in surrounding principles:

- SRA stages should be varied, realistic, and appropriate to the firearm (1.3.5).
- Shooting skill must dominate over non-shooting tasks (1.3.3).
- Speed and accuracy should be balanced under the SRA/TTS principle stated in 1.3.4.
- Swedish rifle/karbine matches require 30% of targets beyond 150 m (1.3.13).

SRA may also include non-shooting tasks, movement, position changes, themed matches, and mandatory reloads, although the competitor chooses where between the first and last shot to perform a mandated reload (1.2.9, 1.3.3, 1.3.7).

Brutality: a stage-defined physical test

The general Brutality rules do not state a comprehensive stage-design philosophy. They establish that:

- every stage has a written description with par time, bonuses, and penalties (3.4);
- the description is read and followed by questions (3.4.1);
- competitors normally start standing with the first firearm loaded at low ready and other firearms in Condition 3 (3.5);
- competitors must finish within par or receive par plus applicable penalties (3.6);
- required targets and stage elements may be skipped for penalties in specified circumstances (3.6.1-3.6.2).

Nothing in the general rules requires simple construction, natural terrain, physical tasks, or a particular balance between shooting and athletic performance. Those familiar characteristics of Brutality events are therefore produced mainly by individual stage descriptions and event design, not by detailed central construction rules.

This is the first major structural difference: **IPSC and SRA regulate how designers create the problem; Brutality mostly regulates how the completed problem is briefed and scored.**

2. Physical construction

IPSC construction rules

IPSC Handgun and Rifle devote a full chapter to range and course construction (Chapter 2). Both require designers to consider:

- safe angles, ricochet paths, backstops, and berms;
- safe access and visibility for officials;
- target placement and prevention of shoot-throughs;
- range surface and weather effects;
- physical consistency between competitors;
- fault lines, barriers, Cooper tunnels, props, windows, and ports.

Fault lines are especially standardized (2.2.1). They must normally:

- be rigid and firmly fixed;
- rise at least 2 cm above the ground;
- use a consistent color;
- be at least 1.5 m long unless continuous;
- be treated as extending indefinitely from their ends.

IPSC says physical barriers are preferable for restricting movement, but fault lines may prevent unsafe movement, simulate cover, or define a shooting area. Barriers at least 1.8 m high normally extend upward indefinitely and should have rearward fault lines (2.2.3). This explains the familiar IPSC combination of wall panels, ports, and wooden ground lines.

Handgun contains more provisions for traversed obstacles and full tunnels (2.2.2, 2.2.4). Those paragraphs are “not applicable” in the Rifle rules, but Rifle retains barriers, Cooper tunnels, props, windows, and ports. Thus, IPSC Rifle and Handgun share the same visual grammar, although Rifle typically uses fewer close-range obstacle types and more distance.

SRA construction rules

SRA contains a shorter but recognizable equivalent (1.4):

- barricades, tunnels, boundary lines, and cover lines may direct or limit movement and shooting;
- a boundary line controls movement within the shooting area, and crossing it produces a procedural penalty;
- a cover line may force shooting from behind physical cover, must be at least 1 m long, extends indefinitely, and must remain fixed;
- full and Tiitinen/Cooper tunnels may be used;
- lower-level matches may use only lines when full construction is impractical.

SRA is less prescriptive than IPSC about dimensions, wall height, ports, obstacle testing, anchoring, and surface preparation. Nevertheless, it clearly anticipates constructed stages. A simple SRA stage is allowed at lower levels, but simple construction is an exception expressly tied to range rules, time, or material constraints (1.4.5).

Brutality construction rules

The supplied Brutality book has no comparable chapter. It does not define:

- fault or boundary lines;

- walls, barriers, ports, or tunnels;
- obstacle dimensions or testing;
- stage surface requirements;
- target visibility or presentation balance;
- maximum round counts or target distributions;
- a required ratio of short and long stages.

This silence gives designers broad freedom. A Brutality stage can be a straightforward path between a few shooting positions, a natural-terrain course, or a complex prop-based test without contradicting the general rules. The practical simplicity observed at events is therefore compatible with the rules, but not mandated by them.

3. Briefing and walkthrough

IPSC

IPSC distinguishes published and non-published courses, but both ultimately require competitors to receive adequate and equal stage information (3.1). The written stage briefing must be posted, approved by the Range Master, and include at least targets, minimum rounds, ready conditions, start position, start signal, and procedure. Rifle briefings also identify target distances and balance (3.2.1).

The RO must:

1. read the briefing verbatim to each squad;
2. demonstrate the acceptable start position;
3. answer questions;
4. permit an orderly walkthrough of equal duration;
5. demonstrate moving targets equally to all competitors (3.2.2-3.2.4).

The walkthrough is therefore an **equal-information mechanism**, not a prescribed movement plan. Competitors inspect target availability, lines of sight, shooting positions, transitions, and movement options, then choose their own plan under the freestyle principle.

IPSC limits rehearsal during inspection. Competitors may not use replica guns, firearm parts, or other sighting aids during a walkthrough; only their hands may be used (8.7.2). Entry onto the course also requires RO or RM permission (8.7.3).

SRA

SRA rule 4.1.3 requires a detailed briefing covering firearms, targets, scoring, distances, ammunition requirement, maximum points, muzzle and firing limits, safety and waiting areas, cover/boundary lines, and **the allowed time to dry-practice or walk through the stage**. Optional information includes start position, firearm condition, penalties, special restrictions, and scenario.

The RO must ensure that the competitor has understood the briefing, and the command sequence includes a specific opportunity for questions (4.1.4, 4.2.1).

SRA therefore does not merely tolerate walkthroughs. It requires the briefing to state the permitted walkthrough time. It is less detailed than IPSC about identical moving-target demonstrations and prohibited walkthrough aids, but the functional model is close: known constraints, inspection, then a freestyle solution.

Brutality

Brutality requires a written description, an oral reading, clarifications, and question time (3.4-3.4.1). It does **not** specify:

- a mandatory list of targets, distances, muzzle limits, start signal, or movement limits in the description;
- posting or prior approval of the description;
- a walkthrough or equal inspection period;
- how moving targets or hidden elements must be demonstrated;
- restrictions on rehearsal aids;
- whether stages may be blind or partly unknown.

Consequently, the general rules permit an organizer to offer a full walkthrough, a limited observation period, or no walkthrough, provided any operative instructions are conveyed consistently enough to run the stage. The rulebook itself does not resolve which practice applies.

There is also a hierarchy difference. Brutality says an RO ruling overrides the written stage description, which overrides division rules and the general rules (3.4.2). IPSC requires the written briefing to be consistent with the central rules, while SRA requires official instructions to remain within safety rules. Brutality consequently gives the individual stage and RO more immediate discretion.

4. Movement, knowledge, and coaching

IPSC shooters know:

- the stage procedure and start condition;
- the physical limits and target presentations;
- what the moving targets do;
- that they received the same inspection opportunity as their squad.

They do not normally receive a mandatory route. IPSC and SRA both protect freestyle choice and use physical construction to create options and constraints. The competitive skill includes selecting and executing a route.

Brutality can create a different experience because sparse construction, target calls, par time, and stage-specific instructions can make the route more linear or task-oriented. More importantly, Brutality rule 3.8 says ROs coach all competitors unless a competitor opts out. IPSC prohibits assistance during the course except safety warnings (8.6.1). SRA defines the preventive **MANOVER/WATCH OUT** safety warning but does not establish general performance coaching (4.2.1).

This produces a meaningful contrast:

- **IPSC:** inspect equally, plan independently, receive safety warnings only.
- **SRA:** receive a detailed briefing and walkthrough time, solve freely, receive preventive safety warnings.
- **Brutality:** receive the stage brief and questions, potentially face less standardized prior inspection, and receive RO coaching by default.

5. Stage consistency and changes

IPSC and SRA treat consistent presentation as part of competitive equity.

IPSC marks target and stand locations, regulates target replacement, and requires RM-approved changes (2.1.8, 2.3). Material changes may require affected or all competitors to reshoot; if equality cannot be restored, the stage and all its scores must be deleted.

SRA permits a stage to be changed during the match only for safety reasons. A non-trivial change requires previous competitors to reshoot, or the stage must be removed if a reshoot is impossible (1.3.10).

Brutality grants reshoots for prop or target failure when a roughly equivalent alternative cannot be improvised (3.9.3). The express acceptance of improvisation reflects a more pragmatic event model. It may preserve match flow, but gives less formal assurance that every competitor encounters an identical physical problem.

6. The effect of firearm-ready rules

All four books regulate firearm condition at the start, but this is distinct from stage inspection.

IPSC Handgun normally starts with a loaded, holstered handgun unless otherwise briefed (8.2). IPSC Rifle defines three ready options: chamber loaded, magazine loaded with empty chamber, and unloaded (8.1). Empty-chamber or unloaded starts should comprise no more than 25% of a match (Handgun 1.2.1.5; Rifle 1.2.1.5).

SRA defines its own detailed load and start command sequence, with a default standing start and firearm-specific ready positions (4.2.1).

Brutality normally starts with the first firearm loaded at low ready and all other firearms holstered or slung in Condition 3 (3.5). Outside RO-supervised loading, the match is a cold range (1.2).

None of these provisions, by itself, makes a stage “cold” in the blind-stage sense. Ready condition controls the gun; walkthrough rules control prior knowledge.

7. Overall findings

IPSC Handgun and Rifle

The two disciplines use nearly identical construction, briefing, walkthrough, freestyle, and consistency rules. Handgun supports more close-range obstacle and tunnel designs and higher round counts. Rifle substitutes longer target distances, lower ordinary round counts, and rifle-specific ready conditions.

The familiar wall-panel and fault-line stage is not merely custom. It follows directly from IPSC's preference for physical restrictions, standardized fault lines, barriers with rearward lines, and equal course presentation.

SRA/TTS

SRA is a middle case in level of detail, but conceptually belongs beside IPSC. It codifies freestyle solutions, construction-based restrictions, barricades, tunnels, lines, detailed stage briefings, and walkthrough time. Compared with IPSC it places more emphasis on realism, military relevance, long-range rifle shooting, and optional non-shooting tasks.

Brutality

Brutality is stage-centric rather than construction-centric. Its general rulebook establishes safety, start state, briefing, par time, target neutralization, coaching, and reshoots, then leaves most physical design to the organizer. This supports simpler and more varied terrain-based stages but creates fewer central guarantees concerning inspection, geometry, route choice, and identical presentation.

Conclusion

Your practical distinction is broadly correct, but the documents sharpen it as follows:

- **IPSC builds a standardized physical shooting problem and gives competitors equal inspection before they choose a freestyle solution.**
- **SRA uses much of the same model, with less construction detail and more realism and military-task emphasis.**
- **Brutality defines the task and scoring but largely leaves construction and inspection practice to each event or stage.**

The decisive divide is not simply “complex IPSC walls versus simple Brutality terrain.” It is **central standardization versus local stage discretion**. IPSC regulates the stage as sporting infrastructure; SRA regulates a similar but more field-oriented stage; Brutality regulates the competitor's attempt while saying comparatively little about how the stage itself must be built or revealed.